



LISTENING

#16

1 – Listen to a conversation between a guest and a hotel clerk. Answer the questions to understand the reservation details, the problem with the booking, the rooms that are available, the prices and discounts offered, and how the situation is resolved.

Hotel Check-in

1 - What name does the guest give for the reservation?

2 - How many guests did the clerk first say the reservation was for?

3 - What did the guest think “a room for five” meant?

4 - What date did the clerk first say the reservation was for instead of tonight?

5 - Why did the clerk say there were no normal rooms available for tonight?

6 - What room became available because of a cancellation?

7 - How much did the clerk say the honeymoon suite would cost?

8 - What date does the clerk first find on the record for the guest's reservation?

(Mark the correct answer.)

☐ Tonight

☐ Yesterday's night

☐ The 19th

9 - What additional compensation did the clerk offer at the end to apologize for the problem?

10 - If you worked at the hotel, how would you help the guest in this situation?

Hour-long check-in delays loom at Spanish hotels

Holidaymakers who have booked a trip in Spain this summer are arriving to their hotels and discovering significant delays at check-in due to stringent new regulations.

The rules which came into effect in December 2024, are causing considerable delays as they require hotels, private rentals, and car hire companies to collect extensive personal information and share it with the Spanish Ministry of Interior, raising concerns over privacy and the potential for unchecked child trafficking.

Under the new system, hotels must collate up to 42 pieces of data from each guest, including full names, passport or ID numbers, addresses, dates of birth, email addresses, phone numbers, bank details, and even relationships to accompanying travelers. The shift from the previous quick ID scans to manual data entry is leading to long waits at reception, in some cases hours, at hotels all over the country.

Jorge Marichal, president of the Spanish Confederation of Hotels and Tourist Accommodation (Cehat), has said the process is like “applying for a visa to the United States,” warning that check-ins are taking significantly longer, especially for groups and families.

Hotel check-in delays said to be in interests of ‘security’

The Spanish government claims the measures are to improve national security by combating terrorism and organized crime. However, the requirement to transmit sensitive information, including bank card details, to the authorities has alarmed tourists and privacy advocates. The Spanish Data Protection Agency has already ruled that photocopying IDs is illegal, a common practice for many years in Spain, forcing hotels to manually input data to avoid privacy violations, further slowing the process.

Critics are particularly concerned about glaring loopholes in the process which cancel out the claim of ‘security’ from the government. The new rules exempt children under 14 from the data collection. While this is said to protect young guests’ privacy, it raises serious questions about the effectiveness of the regulations in preventing child trafficking. With no mandatory records of minors staying at hotels, authorities may struggle to track vulnerable children, potentially undermining the security goals of the new law.

Holidaymakers are advised to prepare for a much longer wait at check-in times and ensure their personal details are accurate and to-hand to avoid delays. Those privacy-conscious travelers may also want to ask at reception about how the hotel is going to handle and store that data. The new rules, part of Spain’s broader efforts to regulate tourism, but have sparked debate on platforms like X, where users have labeled the measures “big brother” and an “inquisition.”

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COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS

1 – What reason does the Spanish government give for requiring this extensive data collection?

2 – What advice is given to travelers to help avoid delays at check-in under the new rules?
